

Innovation Framework Scorecard

Version 1.0-draft · 15 questions · 5 principles · ~12 minutes

Source: the Innovators Framework — Part I of Mutation

Readiness: An Operating Manual for Innovation in the Age of AI

Machine-readable source of truth: [innovation-framework-scorecard.yaml](#)

What this measures

The companion to the [Mutation Readiness Scorecard](#). Mutation Readiness measures whether your organization can sense and respond to AI-age change; this scorecard measures whether you have the **cultural operating system underneath that lets innovation happen at all**. Most organizations should run this one first — an organization in Innovation Theatre will fail at Mutation Readiness regardless of what it installs.

How to score

Rate each question 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree); N/A allowed. **Principle score** = sum of three answers (max 15). **Total** = sum of five principles (max 75). If any items are N/A, normalize to a percentage.

Band	Score	Reading
Innovation Theatre	0-30	The language of innovation without the practices. Work is performed for management or external audiences, not lived in daily decisions.
Innovation Practicing	31-55	The rituals exist; the organization hasn't absorbed them into how decisions are made.

Band	Score	Reading
Innovation Native	56-75	The biggest gap is usually between what leadership says and what the performance system rewards. Innovation is identity, not department. The risk is now complacency rather than absence.

The questions

Principle 1 — Fail Forward (Grit & Agility)

Structured experiments, intelligent failure, fast recovery.

- **Q1.1** Does your team run small, structured experiments with explicit hypotheses and pre-defined learning goals — not just “let’s try it and see”?
- **Q1.2** When something fails, do you have a structured way to debrief it (Failure Harvest, post-mortem) that surfaces what the team believed before, what they believe now, and what to do next — without blame?
- **Q1.3** Is iteration and perseverance publicly recognized in your performance system, not just successful outcomes?

Principle 2 — Open Communication & Candid Feedback

Psychological safety combined with radical candor — either one alone collapses.

- **Q2.1** Do team members feel safe to challenge ideas — including ideas from leadership — without political consequence?
- **Q2.2** Is feedback typically shared in real time, rather than saved for annual reviews?
- **Q2.3** When senior leaders make decisions employees disagree with, do those employees say so — and is the disagreement engaged seriously?

Principle 3 — Challenging Mental Models

Questioning assumptions you have been treating as facts.

- **Q3.1** Does your team regularly question fundamental assumptions about your industry, customers, or business model — in real decisions, not workshop exercises?
- **Q3.2** When you face a hard problem, does someone on the team know how to use first-principles reasoning to break it down to underlying physical or economic facts?
- **Q3.3** Has your team explicitly retired a “sacred cow” — a practice everyone assumed was non-negotiable — in the past 12 months?

Principle 4 — Flexible Structure / Agile Decision-Making

Decisions close to the work; information across boundaries faster than up the chain.

- **Q4.1** Are teams aligned to customer outcomes or value streams, rather than to internal functions?
- **Q4.2** Do teams have decision-making autonomy without escalation for most operational choices in their area?
- **Q4.3** When something needs to change structurally, does it happen within a quarter, or does it take a year of approvals?

Principle 5 — Growth Mindset at Scale

How the organization rewards effort and learning vs talent and outcomes.

- **Q5.1** Does your performance review system explicitly reward how an employee helped others grow — with comparable weight to delivery metrics?
- **Q5.2** Do employees have dedicated, protected time for self-directed learning, experimentation, or curiosity-driven work?
- **Q5.3** When senior leaders fail or change their minds, do they share what they learned, publicly, more than once a year?

Rapid mode

Five questions — the strongest single signal per principle: Q1.2, Q2.1, Q3.3, Q4.3, Q5.1. Score out of 25. Bands: 0–10 Theatre, 11–18 Practicing, 19–25 Native.

After scoring

The work program targets the **weakest one or two principles**, never all five at once — five concurrent culture initiatives is the failure mode of every culture change. Band-specific playbooks (including the smallest-possible practice to install per principle) are in the [Claude Code skill](#), which also runs the assessment conversationally and writes a 30-60-90-day plan.

If you score above 55 — or above 40 with momentum — run the [Mutation Readiness Scorecard](#) next: the cultural foundation is necessary but not sufficient for the AI age.